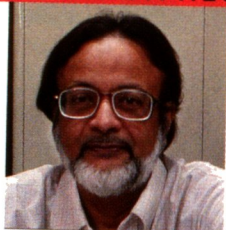


PRINCIPALSPEAK

SANJIB GHOSH, Presidency College, Kolkata



“OUR AIM IS TO NURTURE scientists from among the 3,000 applicants every year for various science subjects.”

around 25 per cent of the seats are offered to poor and underprivileged students. Principal Father Albert Muthumalai says such moves have been the outcome of a visionary guidance received at the 34th general congregation of members of the Society of Jesus, conducted in Rome in 1995. “From all over the world 223 Jesuit delegates vowed to take an active role in reducing the widening gap between the rich and poor, the literate and the illiterate in a globalised era,” he says.

D. Rajasekaran, a Dalit student doing M.Phil at the zoology department, says, “Loyola has always been supportive of first generation college-goers and students from deprived sections.” Groups comprising five students are each mentored by a faculty member, which ensures personalised attention. Well thought-out outreach programmes, mentoring schemes, personality development and spoken English programmes are conducted to raise confidence and communication skills of such students. “These students lag behind only in the first year. From second year on, they gain confidence, cover lost ground and shine like a diamond in Loyola’s crown,” says Father Muthumalai.

There’s an equal measure of radiance in the corridors of St Stephen’s, Delhi. With an accomplished faculty, well-equipped laboratories and the distinction of being Stephenians, science students of this college are envied and admired in the same breath. The programmes being offered include physics, chemistry and computer science. The physics honours course, in particular, is very popular. The approach to science education at Stephen’s is concept-based, with the faculty going out of their way to create students’ interest in the fundamentals, even if it means moving out of the limits of the prescribed syllabus. Says Karam Malhotra, a student, “Many of



VIKRAM SHARMA

our teachers are active scientists. They go abroad on research and bring out papers during the summers.” Research opportunities are also ample for students who assist their faculty and take up summer projects in top-notch institutes. Invariably, many of these students end up studying further at places like the Indian Institute of Science, TIFR, Oxford and Cornell.

Presidency College, Kolkata also focuses on rearing scholars for the future, beyond just a university degree and the marksheet. The college, which offers PG and undergraduate courses in various science subjects, has a galaxy of distinguished professors, lecturers

TOP NOTCH: An accomplished faculty drives St Stephen’s, Delhi

and readers with state-of-the-art laboratories and research facilities. Seminars involving top scientists are held regularly. Principal Sanjib Ghosh says the college receives nearly 3,000 applications every year for subjects like physics, chemistry and mathematics. “Our aim is to nurture scientists,” he says. In other words, these colleges ensure a conducive environment for students to prepare themselves for a higher calling.

with Sharmila Dhal, Elora Sen and Deepti Bharthur